

PROMPTING HELPER / QUICKSTART

Quickstart: from nothing to your first picture

Eleven short steps. Do them in order and you have your first picture, made with your own character, in under an hour. Most of that hour is downloads. You don't need any programming knowledge; every button is named exactly as it appears on screen.

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13 SECTIONS

PROMPTING HELPER / USER GUIDE

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Before you start

Prompting Helper is where you work: characters, models, prompts and the **Render** button. **ComfyUI** is the program that actually paints the picture on your graphics card. The app installs ComfyUI for you, starts it and talks to it. You never have to open ComfyUI yourself.

Graphics card
Windows PC with an NVIDIA card (8 GB video memory or more), or a Mac with Apple Silicon (M1 or newer).

Disk space
At least 30 GB free. Models are big; more is better.

Internet
The setup downloads ComfyUI and several gigabytes of model files.

No graphics card?

You can render online with **Comfy Cloud** (paid per use). At step 2, answer `On Comfy Cloud` instead of `On this PC`, and skip the ComfyUI install.

Words used in this guide

- **Checkpoint**: the main image model (2–7 GB). It decides the overall look.
- **LoRA**: a small add-on to a checkpoint (10–300 MB): a style, a character, a pose.
- **Base model**: the family a checkpoint belongs to, for example *Illustrious*, *Krea 2* or *Anima*. A LoRA only works with checkpoints of its own family.
- **Workflow**: the recipe ComfyUI follows. The app ships ready-made ones; you just pick one.

SECTION 01

Install the app

1. Open **github.com/valerie-4659/promptinghelper-app/releases**.
2. Under the newest release, open **Assets** and download the file for your system:
   - Windows: `promptinghelper-<version>.exe`
   - Mac: `promptinghelper-<version>.dmg`
   - Linux: `.AppImage` or `.deb`
3. Install it like any other program and start it.

A security warning on the first start is normal

The app is not signed with a paid certificate, so your system warns you once.

- **Windows** ("Windows protected your PC"): click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.
- **Mac** ("cannot be opened"): open **System Settings › Privacy & Security**, scroll down and click **Open Anyway**.

Updates come by themselves: on Windows and with the AppImage the app offers to install a new version; on a Mac it tells you a new version is out.

SECTION 02

Install and set up ComfyUI

On the very first start the app asks one question: **"Do you want to render pictures with ComfyUI?"**

1. Click **Yes, render with ComfyUI**.
2. "Where should ComfyUI run?" Click **On this PC**. (No graphics card: **On Comfy Cloud**, paste your key from cloud.comfy.org, **Test**, then **Finish — show my settings**. Then go on with step 3.)

Now the **setup assistant** opens. It has eight steps, shown as a row at the top. Nothing happens until you press a button.

1. **Welcome**: click **Let's start**.
2. **Folders**: click **Choose a drive or folder...** and pick a drive with lots of free space, for example `D:\AI`. The app makes two folders inside it: one for ComfyUI itself, one for your models and pictures. Click **Use these folders**.

   > **Why two folders?**
   >
   > Your models live outside ComfyUI. If ComfyUI ever breaks, a fresh one finds all your models again, without downloading anything.

3. **ComfyUI**: click **Download ComfyUI for me**. On Windows, check **Your graphics card** (NVIDIA, AMD or Intel Arc; the app picks it for you). Click **Download and unpack** (Mac and Linux: **Download and install**). It is about 2 GB. Already have ComfyUI? Click **I have ComfyUI** and choose its folder instead.
4. **Graphics card**: leave **Keep models on the graphics card** ticked. Tick **Keep 2 GB of the card free** only if renders later stop with "out of memory". Click **Next**.
5. **Nodes and models**: "Which models will you use?" Tick the families you want. **For a first start, Illustrious alone is enough**: it is the easiest and needs the least download. Click **Set it up** and wait until it says **Done.**, then **Next**.
6. **Start**: click **Start ComfyUI**. The first start takes a minute or two. When it says **"ComfyUI is running"**, click **Next: your first checkpoint**.
7. **First model**: this is step 6 of this guide. You can do it right here or later. Click **Next**.

8. **AI services** (optional): paste an AI key here if you have one (step 5 explains why). Click **Finish**.

> **Is it running?**
> The sidebar has a small lamp for the server. Green means ComfyUI answers. Click it to start, stop or restart ComfyUI. If you press Render while ComfyUI is stopped, the app asks **Start and render** and does both.

Closed the assistant too early? Open **Settings › 01 Overview**. The page shows what is missing, each with one button that fixes it, plus the card **Add a new ComfyUI**.

SECTION 03

Connect the Crosspost Helper

The **Crosspost Helper** is the sister app for your picture library and for posting. Connected, its Reference Library shows up in Prompting Helper as example pictures, and finished pictures can be sent there (posts, videos). **Skip this step if you don't use the Crosspost Helper.**

1. Start the Crosspost Helper on the same computer and leave it running.
2. In Prompting Helper open **Settings › 07 Phone & other apps** and find **Crosspost Helper**.
3. Click **Test connection**. It should say **"Connected — the Reference Library is available in the Examples picker."**

That's all; reading needs no password. Only if you want Prompting Helper to *write* prompts back into the Crosspost Helper: copy the pairing token in the Crosspost Helper, then in Prompting Helper open the fold **Advanced — Phone & other apps** and paste it into **Pairing token**. Click **Save** at the top right.

SECTION 04

Install the Chrome extension

The extension puts a **Download** button into civitai.com: one click and a checkpoint or LoRA lands in the right folder and in your library, with its preview and settings. It also sends pictures from the web into your Example Images. It works in Chrome, Edge and Brave.

It is not in the Chrome Web Store, so you load it once by hand:

1. In the app, open **Settings › 07 Phone & other apps** and find **Browser Extension**.
2. Click **Make a token** (or **Copy token** if one exists). The token is now on your clipboard.
3. Click **Open the folder**. A folder called `browser-extension` opens. Remember where it is.
4. In Chrome, type `chrome://extensions` in the address bar and press Enter.
5. Switch on **Developer mode** (top right).
6. Click **Load unpacked** and choose the `browser-extension` folder.

7. Click the puzzle piece in Chrome's toolbar and pin the extension. Click its icon. It shows **"Connect to Prompting Helper"**: paste the token into **Pairing token** and click **Pair**.

> **After every app update**
> Open `chrome://extensions` and press the round reload arrow on the extension, so it matches the new app.

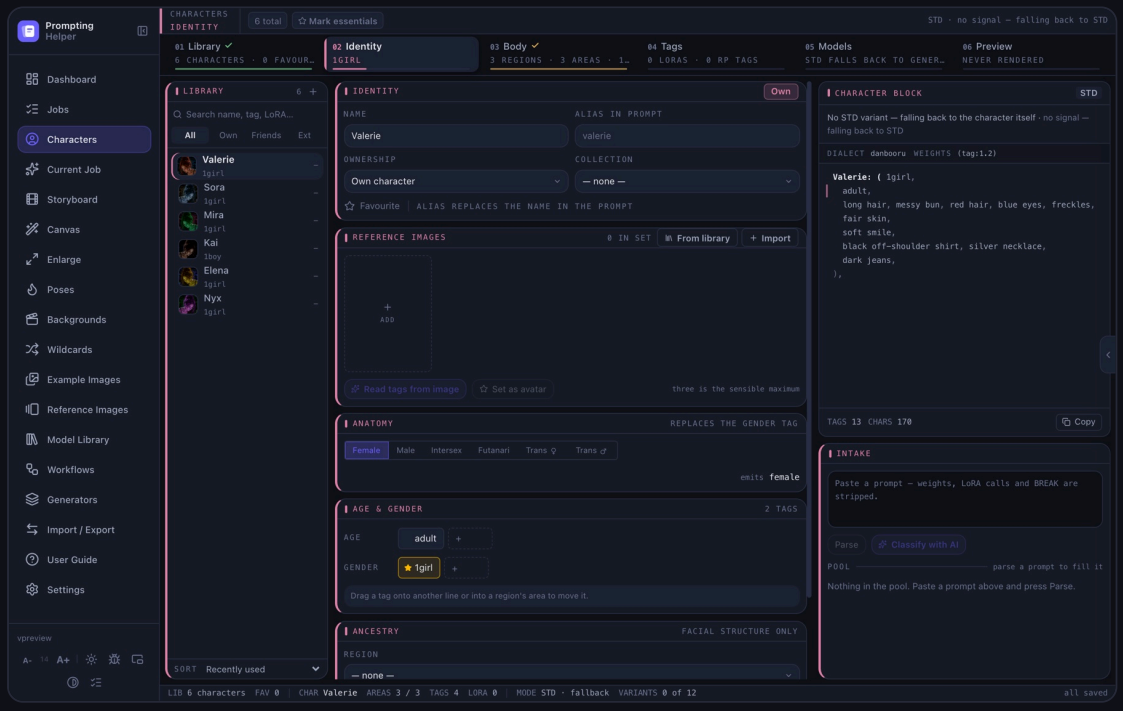
The setup assistant's step **First model** shows the same four steps with buttons (**Open folder**, **Copy address**, **Copy token**).

SECTION 05

Create your first character

A character is a saved description of one person: face, hair, body, clothes. You build her once; every picture she is in gets the same description.

1. Click **Characters** in the sidebar.
2. Click the **+** at the top of the Library column. A character called *New Character* appears.
3. Stage **02 Identity**: type her **Name**, pick her **Anatomy** (Female, Male, ...) and her **Age & gender**.
4. Stage **03 Body**: under **Regions & areas** click **Add area** and pick **Hair**, **Eyes**, **Clothing** ... Type a tag into each, for example `long red hair`, `green eyes`, `black leather jacket`.
5. Click **Save** at the top (or Ctrl+S).



02 Identity: name, reference images, anatomy, age and gender.

Faster: let the AI describe her from pictures

Have pictures of her? The AI reads them and fills in the character for you. For this you need **one AI key**:

1. Get a key from an AI provider. **Grok (xAI)** is the recommended one; it also reads mature pictures.
2. Open `Settings › 03 Services & keys › AI Provider API Keys`, paste it into **Grok key**, click `Test`, then `Save`. (The sidebar entry **AI Analysis** only appears once a key is saved.)

Then:

1. In stage `02 Identity`, rack **Reference images**: add one to three pictures of her with `Import` (or `From library`).
2. Click `Analyze her pictures`. The app switches to **AI Analysis** with her pictures loaded and the **Character** lens set.
3. Click `Read N regions` and wait. The AI reads hair, eyes, face, body, clothes and marks.
4. Go through the stages **Read · Settle · Send**. In **Send** the destination is already *Update a character* with her name. Optional: under **Also write a variant for** tick the base models you use, so she gets wording made for each.
5. Click `Apply N changes`. Back in Characters, check her and click `Save`.

> **No pictures yet?**
> Drop any picture into `AI Analysis` (Drop · paste · browse), pick the Character lens, read it, and in Send choose `New character`.

SECTION 06

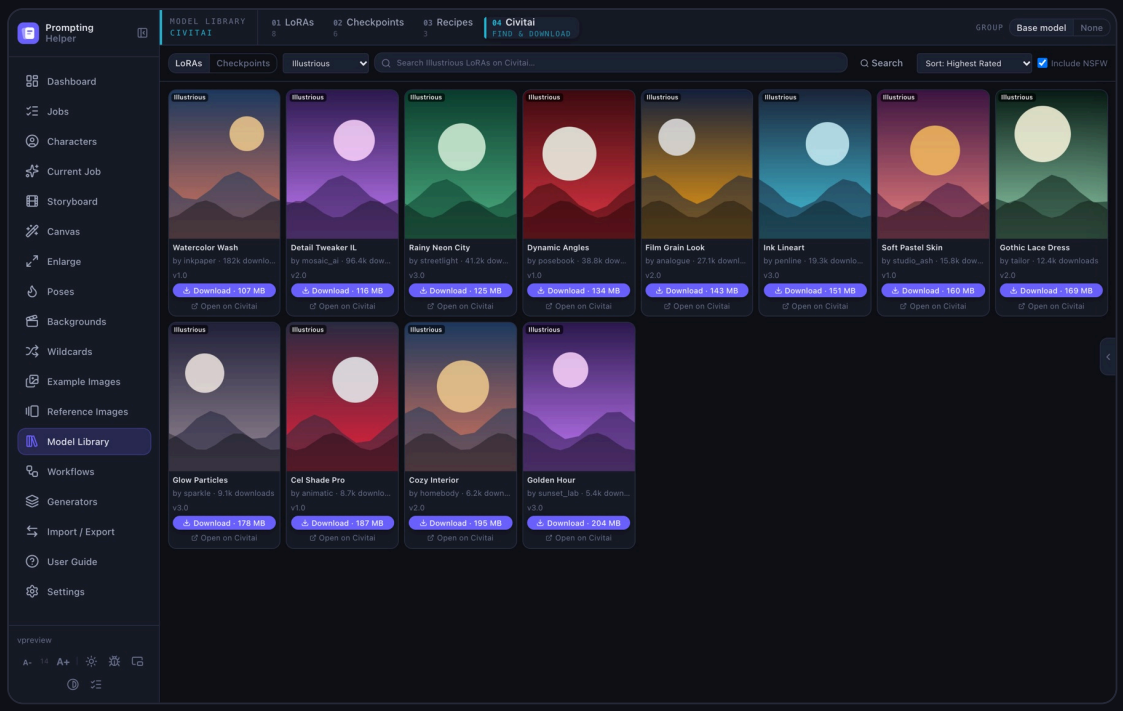
Add checkpoints and LoRAs

The assistant installed everything except the one thing you choose yourself: **at least one checkpoint**. There are three ways in. Pick one.

A. Download inside the app (easiest)

1. Open `Model Library` in the sidebar, tab `04 Civitai`.
2. Switch to `Checkpoints`, choose the **Base model** first (for example *Illustrious*), then search or browse.
3. Click `Download · <size>` on a tile. When it is done the tile says **In library**. Done: the file is in the right folder and the library already knows its settings.

Some models only download with a Civitai key: paste yours in `Settings › 03 Services & keys › CivitAI Integration`.



Model Library › Civitai: base model first, then search, then Download.

B. From civitai.com with the extension

Browse civitai.com in Chrome as usual. On a model page the extension's block offers one download button. The file goes into your models folder and into the library by itself.

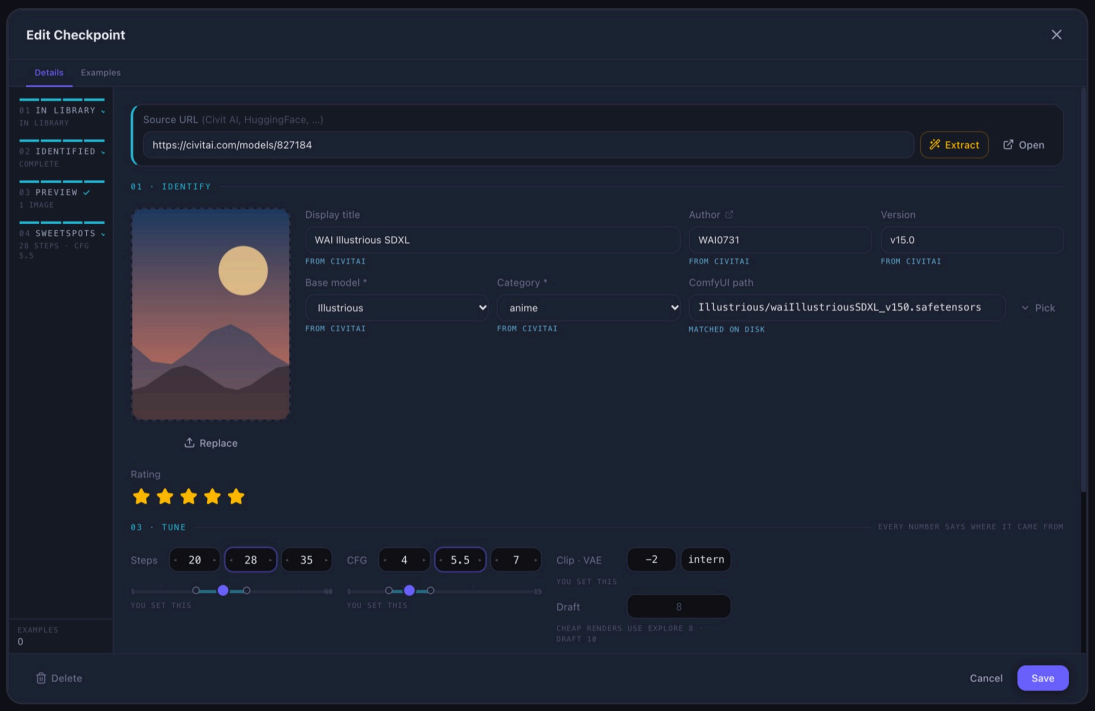
C. Files you already have

1. Put them into the models folder the assistant made (`checkpoints` or `loras` inside it), or tell the app about your existing folders: **Settings › 01 Overview**, card **Bind my folders**.
2. In the **Model Library**, tab **02 Checkpoints**, a bar says "N files on disk are not in the library". Click **Catalog all**. Same on **01 LoRAs**.

Let Civitai and the AI fill in the settings

Every checkpoint wants its own **steps**, **CFG** and **sampler**. Wrong numbers give muddy or burnt pictures. The app looks them up for you:

- **Many at once**: after cataloging, the bar says "N checkpoints know nothing but their filename". Click **Set them up**, then **Auto Fix Metadata**. For each checkpoint the app finds it on Civitai by its file fingerprint, takes title, base model, recommended settings and trigger words, lets the AI fill what Civitai doesn't say, and saves. LoRAs get the same with **Auto Mode** (Civitai data only).
- **One by one**: click a checkpoint to open **Edit Checkpoint**. Paste its Civitai page into **Source URL** (or click **DB Lookup**, which finds it by its file), then **Extract**. Take the values with **Apply** per row or **Apply All**. Still gaps? ✨ **AI Enhance** proposes the missing numbers. Click **Save**.



Edit Checkpoint: Source URL and Extract at the top, Base model and Category under 01 Identify, Steps and CFG under 03 Tune.

> **Two fields must be right**
>
> **Base model** and **Category** are marked with a star. If Base model is wrong, the checkpoint won't show up in a job of that family.

For a LoRA, check two things in its form: **Trigger Words** (the words that switch it on) and **Weight range** (how strong it may be set; the Civitai page usually says).

SECTION 07

Create your first job

A **job** is one project: one way of rendering, one model family, its own prompt and settings. You can have as many as you like and switch between them.

1. Click **Jobs** in the sidebar, then **New setup** (on the Dashboard the button is called **New job**).
2. **Service**: click **ComfyUI API (local)** (or **ComfyUI Cloud** if you render online).
3. **Base model**: choose the family of the checkpoint you downloaded, for example *Illustrious*. Families marked "no workflow yet" have no ready-made recipe; avoid them for now.
4. **Label**: a name, for example "Valerie portraits". Leave it empty for "Job 1".
5. Click **Create & open**.

The base model is fixed for good

The job stays on that family forever: it only offers workflows, checkpoints and LoRAs of that family, and the prompt is written in that family's style. Want another family? Make another job. That is what jobs are for.

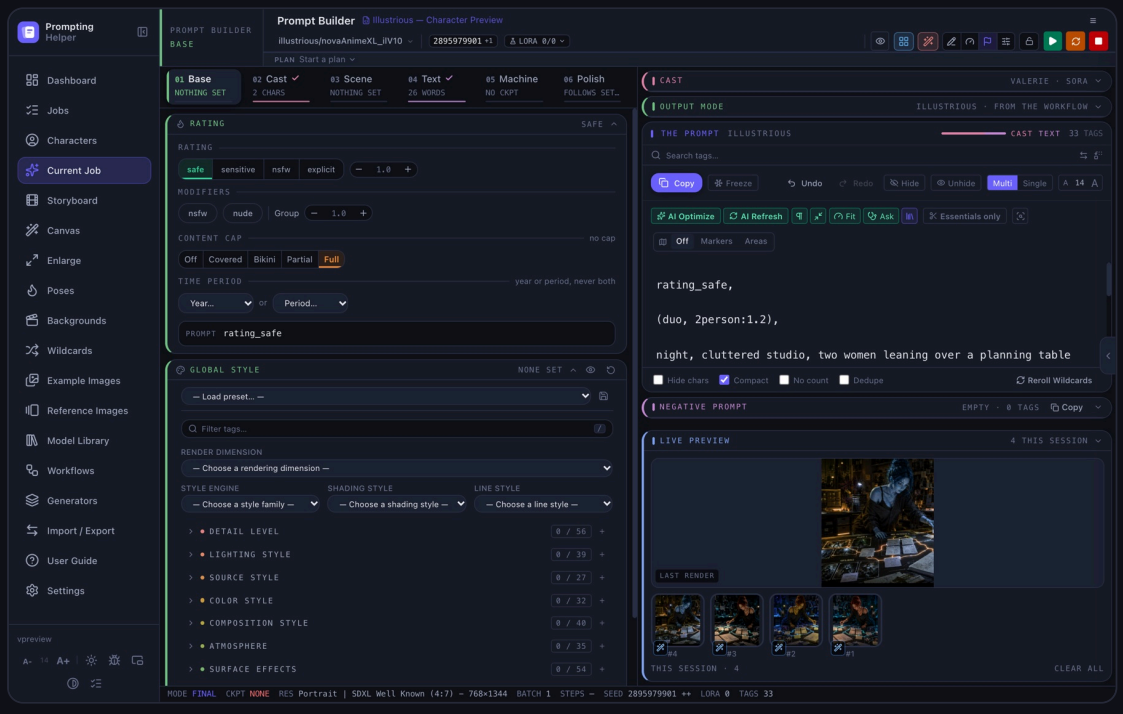
"ComfyUI API (local)" isn't in the list?

The list only shows what is set up. Finish step 2, or open **Settings › 02 ComfyUI & folders › Advanced › Send prompts somewhere else** and pick **ComfyUI**.

SECTION 08

The Prompt Builder: a walk through the stages

The job opens in the **Prompt Builder** (sidebar: **Current Job**). On the left, a row of six **stages**, one after the other like an assembly line. On the right, always visible: **The prompt**, exactly as it is sent.



Stage rail at the top left, the open stage below it, The prompt and Live preview on the right, the status bar at the bottom.

Stage	What you do there	First time?
01 Base	**Rating** (safe … explicit) and the global style.	Set the rating.
02 Cast	Who is in the picture.	Add your character.
03 Scene	Background, pose, shot and lighting from ready-made lists.	Optional.
04 Text	Character Settings (framing, stance, clothing level per person), AI Write, the **Description**.	Write the Description (step 9).
05 Machine	Workflow, checkpoint, LoRAs, seed (step 10).	Pick the checkpoint.
06 Polish	Boosters, wildcards, style blocks. Folded away.	Leave it.

Put your character into the picture

1. Click **02 Cast**.
2. In **Characters & Areas** click **+ Add character ▾**, search her name and click her. Her description now stands in the prompt on the right.
3. For two people, add a second one. **+ Add temp** adds a one-off person who exists only in this job.
4. Click **04 Text**. The first card, **Character Settings**, is a table with one row per person: **Frame** (how much of her is visible), **Stance**, **Gaze**, **Level** (how dressed), **Body** and more. The **ALL** row sets a column for everybody at once.

SECTION 09

Write the prompt: Description, Example Images, Mix Board

The **Description** (stage 04 Text) says what happens in the picture: place, action, mood. Your characters' looks come from their character blocks; you don't need to repeat hair and eyes here. Write in plain words, for example: *"sitting at a café table by the window, laughing, afternoon sun"*. There are three ways to fill it.

A. Type it

Just type into the field. That's enough for a first picture.

B. AI Write

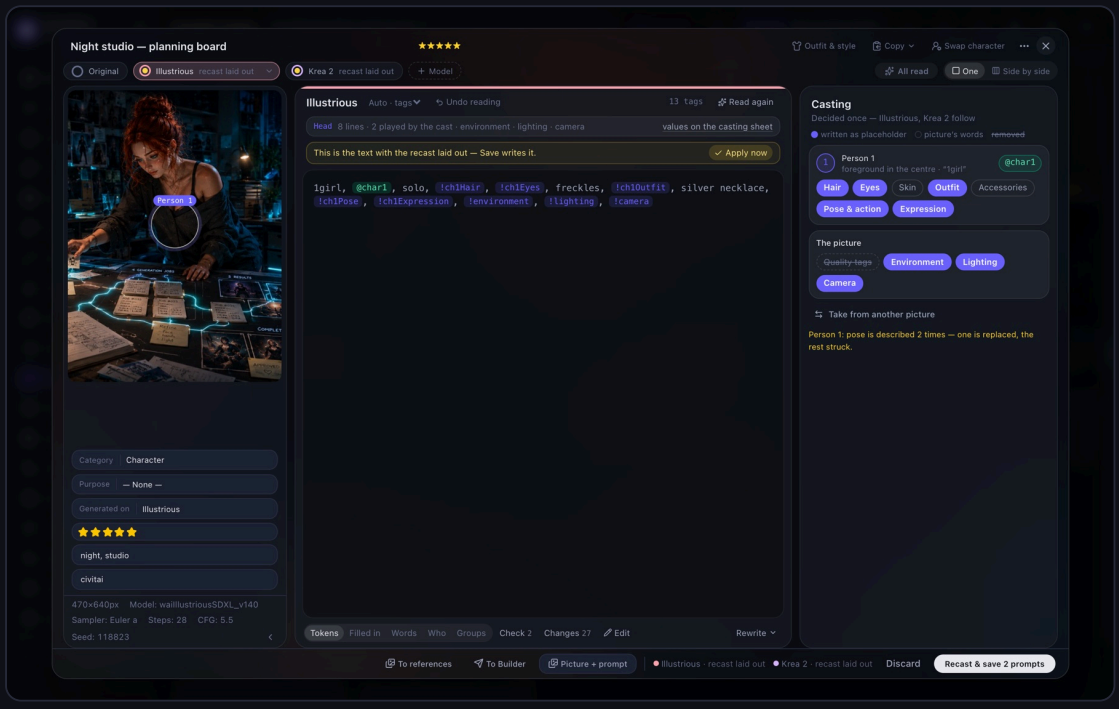
Above the Description: **AI Write**. Choose **New**, type a short idea ("two friends at a rainy bus stop at night"), and the AI writes a full Description in the right style for your model. **Change** edits the one you have, **New pose** gives the same scene a different pose. Every answer replaces the Description; Undo brings the old one back.

C. Take it from a picture you like: Example Images

Seen a picture whose scene you want, with *your* character in it? That is what **Example Images** are for.

1. In the **Reference image** rack (right column) or in the Description's head, click **Examples**. Drop a picture in, or pick one already there (from the extension, the Crosspost Helper or earlier).
2. Click its card. The first time it asks **"Which models should get a prompt?"** Your job's model is ticked. Leave the way to read on **Full reading** and click **Read for N models**.
3. The AI describes the picture. The people in it are replaced by placeholders (`@char1`, `!ch1Hair` ...), so later *your* characters take their place. Rings on the picture show who is Person 1, Person 2.
4. Click **Recast & save N prompts**, then **To Builder** (it says **Replace** when you came from the Builder).

The Description now holds that picture's scene, and your cast fills in the people: your first character plays Person 1, your second Person 2. The app also sets each person's frame and stance from the picture.



An example picture read for one model: the person is a placeholder (@char1, !ch1Hair ...), Casting on the right says what your cast replaces.

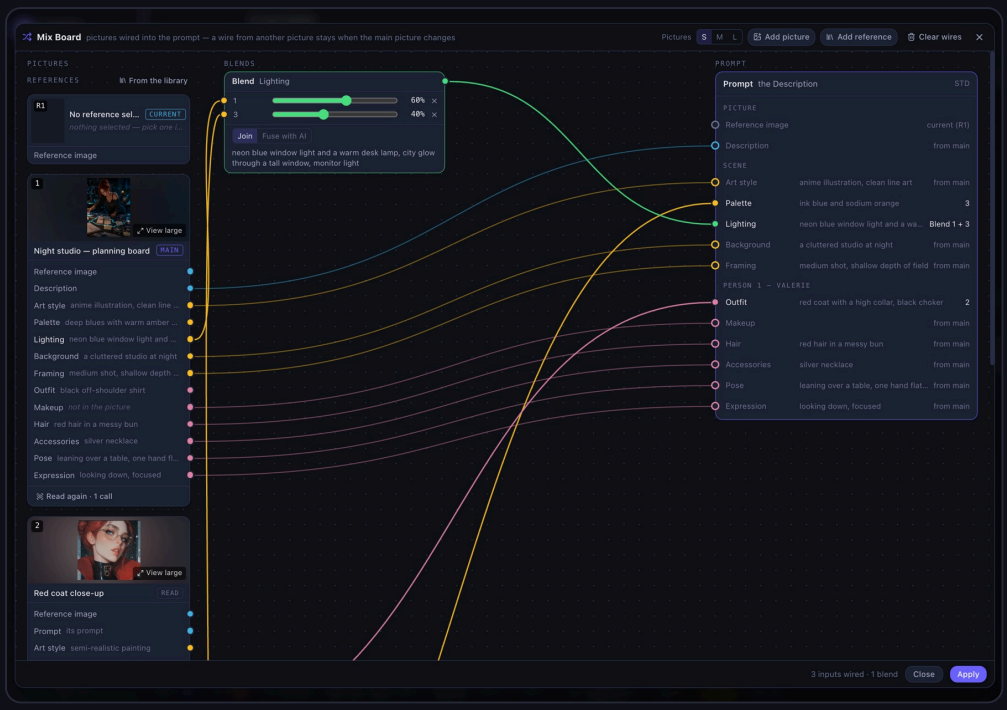
The Mix Board: combine several pictures

Like the pose of one picture, the lighting of a second and the outfit of a third? Click **Mix** (next to Examples). The **Mix Board** has three columns:

- **Pictures** (left): every picture on the board, each with its traits listed: art style, palette, lighting, background, framing, and per person outfit, hair, pose, expression ... **Add picture** puts another one on the board; the AI reads it.
- **Blends** (middle): appear when you mix two pictures into one input, with sliders for how much of each.
- **Prompt** (right): the inputs of your prompt.

Drag a dot from a trait on the left onto an input on the right; a cable shows the connection. That input now comes from that picture. Hold **Shift** while dropping to blend two pictures instead of replacing. Click a cable

to remove it. Inputs you don't wire stay as they are (the faint cables from the main picture). Click **Apply**: everything wired is written into the Description in one go, and one Undo takes it back.



Mix Board: lighting blended from two pictures, the rest taken from the main picture.

SECTION 10

The Machine stage and the workflow settings

Click **05 Machine**. These racks decide *how* the picture is made. For the first picture you only need the first two.

- **Workflow**: the recipe. The list only shows workflows of your job's family. Pick the one called **<your model> — Pipeline v...** (for example *Illustrious — Pipeline v2*); these "Core" workflows ship with the app and are already set up.
- **Checkpoint**: click the name and pick your checkpoint from the library. Its recommended steps, CFG and sampler come with it.
- **Sampling**: steps, CFG, sampler. Leave it: the checkpoint's values are used. The head's **STEPS/CFG** pill shows a dot when you are off the checkpoint's sweet spot; **Use sweet spots** puts them back.
- **img2img**: start from a reference picture instead of noise. Leave it off for now.
- **Seed & batch**: the **seed** is the random number behind the picture. Same seed + same prompt = same picture. **Mode**: **+1** (the default) gives a new picture each render, **Lock** keeps it. **Batch**: how many pictures per press.
- **LoRA & triggers**: **+ Add LoRA** adds one from your library; each gets a strength slider. Its trigger words go into the prompt by themselves. **Pick recipes...** loads a saved set of LoRAs.
- **Bypass & parameters**: the workflow's own switches and numbers (upscale strength, face fix ...). At the top, **Settings** offers **presets**: named value sets such as "Shot — close-up". Pick one that fits your picture; each preset's description says when to take it.

- **Detail pass**: what the face and hand repair passes are told. Leave it.

The picture size is not here: it is the **Resolution** rack in the right column (for example *Portrait 4:7*).

> **Where are my pictures saved?**
> In the renders folder the assistant made. See or change it under **Settings › 02 ComfyUI & folders › Where pictures go** (**Your renders**: named, with their prompt inside).

SECTION 11

Render: Draft, Quality, Final, Lineup

Top right in the Builder's head sits the **rung switch** with four icons, and the **Render** button next to it. The switch decides *how far* the next render goes. **Picking a rung does not render**; it only says what the next press of Render will be.

Rung	What it is	Saved?	Key
Draft	A quick, cheap look: fewer steps, the expensive stages (upscale, face fix) switched off. For trying wording and seeds.	No	Ctrl/⌘+1
Quality	A better look with full steps, still without upscale and detailers.	No	Ctrl/⌘+2
Final	The real render: the whole workflow, upscale and face fix included. The app starts on Final.	**Yes**	Ctrl/⌘+3
Custom	Final, but the bypass switches decide which stages run. For later.	Yes	Ctrl/⌘+4

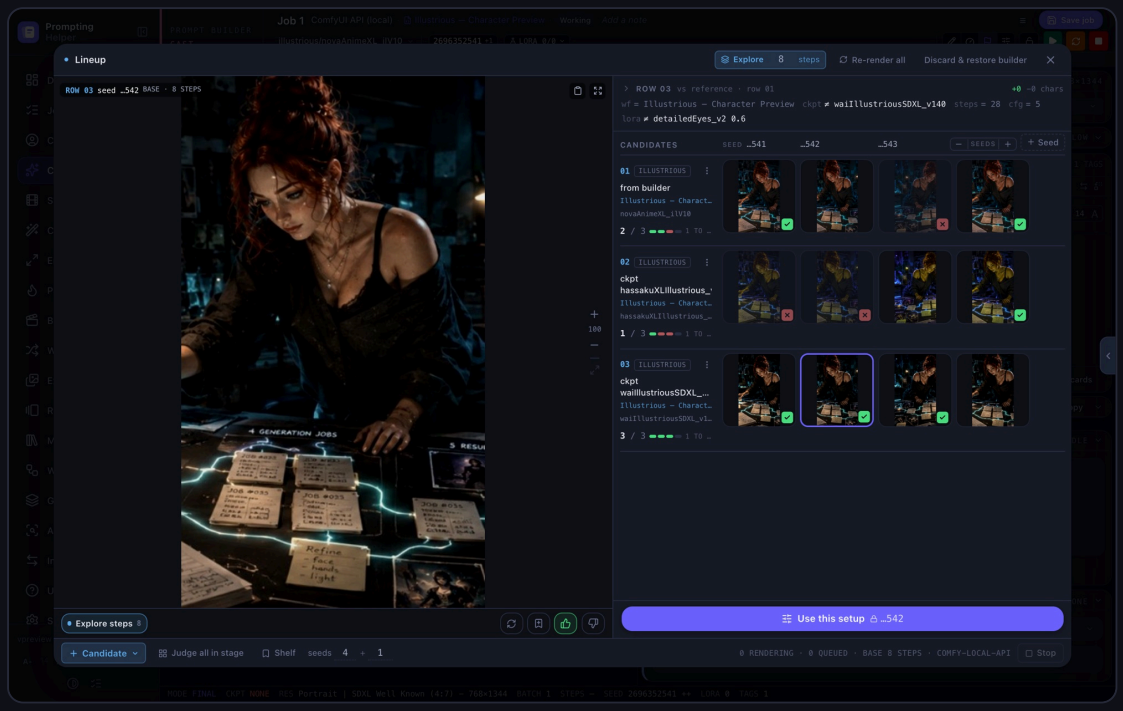
Render: the green ▶ button or **Ctrl+Enter** (⌘+Enter on a Mac). **Re-render** (Ctrl+Shift+Enter) renders again with the same seed. **Stop**: the red button or Ctrl+. (period). Hover a rung to see what it does to *this* workflow: step count, which stages are off, whether a file is written.

> **Your first picture, in three presses**
> 1. Rung on **Draft**, press Render. Look. Change the Description, press again until the idea is right.
> 2. Found a good one? Press **Ctrl+L** (seed lock) so the picture stays the same, then switch to **Quality** and render to check it properly.
> 3. Switch to **Final** and render. This one is saved.

The first render takes longer: ComfyUI loads the model into memory. The result appears in the **Live preview** rack on the right, and every render of every job in the **Gallery** (the drawer on the right edge of the window, opened with its arrow).

Lineup: let the pictures decide

Not sure which checkpoint, LoRA or seed is best? Click **Lineup** in the head. A board opens: **rows are setups** (your current one, plus others you add with **+ Candidate ▾**, for example another checkpoint or a different wording), **columns are seeds**. Every cell renders cheaply, side by side. Give cells a thumbs up or down, then click **Use this setup** on the winner: its settings and seed go into the Builder, and you finish it there with Quality and Final. Nothing in the Lineup is saved to disk; the board stays until you click **Discard**.



The Lineup: three setups across four seeds, the picked cell large on the left, Use this setup at the bottom.

Good to know

- **Queue**: the status bar at the bottom shows **QUEUE**; click it to see what is rendering and waiting, and to cancel.
- **Process** (next to the rungs): for rough "blockout" pictures you don't want to keep. They are parked in Example Images › Process images instead of the output folder.
- How cheap Draft is: **Settings › 05 Rendering › Render Steps**.

If something goes wrong

The sidebar lamp is red, or Render says ComfyUI isn't answering.

Click the lamp and press Start. Wait a minute. If it stops again, the console in that panel says why.

The checkpoint picker is empty.

The job only shows checkpoints of its base model, and only ones in the library. Check step 6: Catalog all, and the checkpoint's **Base model** field.

The render fails with "Value not in list" or a missing node.

ComfyUI lacks a file or node the workflow needs. Usually the error view offers one button that installs what is missing and restarts ComfyUI. Otherwise:
Settings › 02 ComfyUI & folders › What the workflows need, tick your model family, download, restart.

It is extremely slow (30 seconds or more per step).

In **Settings › 02 ComfyUI & folders** open your ComfyUI, tick **Keep models on the graphics card** and restart it.

"Out of memory".

Tick **Keep 2 GB of the card free** there, or use a smaller resolution and a batch of 1.

My picture isn't in the output folder.

Only **Final** (and Custom) save. Draft and Quality are for looking.

The picture looks muddy or burnt.

The checkpoint's steps and CFG are probably wrong. Open it in the Model Library and do "Let Civitai and the AI fill in the settings" (step 6).

Where to go next

The User Guide (**User Guide** in the sidebar) has a chapter for every part of the app: the Prompt Builder in depth, characters, workflows, references and masks, the Canvas for repairs, the phone, and backups.